

SAKSHI BHALLA

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EDUCATION

Ph.D., Media & Communications 2021–present
University of Illinois, Urbana-Champaign · Honors: Phi Kappa Phi

M.S., Statistics 2025
University of Illinois, Urbana-Champaign

M.A., Linguistics 2018–2020
Jawaharlal Nehru University, New Delhi · Entrance Test: All India Rank 1

B.A. (Honors), Journalism 2012–2015
Lady Shri Ram College for Women, University of Delhi

RESEARCH APPOINTMENTS

Research Scientist May–Aug 2026
Amazon Inc., Arlington, VA

PEER-REVIEWED ARTICLES

1. [Fact checkers are seldom used by news users on either side of the partisan divide.](#) With R. Ray and H. Taneja. *Journal of Communication*, 2026.
2. [Classroom Contexts: Teachers Talk Teaching Media Literacy.](#) With M. Nelson and M. Spikes. *Journal of Media Literacy Education*, 2025.
3. [When news is entertainment: Explaining the persistence of misinformation through the information environment.](#) With R. Ray and H. Taneja. *Information, Communication & Society*, 2025.
4. [Climate Strikes in Millennial India: Social Capital and “On-Ground” Networks in Digital-First Movements.](#) With A. Khan and S. Natarajan. *Communication, Culture & Critique*, 2021.

REPORTS

1. Scope it: Understanding how to measure journalism employment. With J. Henrichsen, L. Lincoln, B. Toff & L. Waananen Jones. Forthcoming.

BOOK CHAPTERS

1. User-defined Repertoires. With H. Taneja. *Elgar Encyclopedia of Political Communication*, 2025. Nai, A., Grömping, M., & Wirz, D. (Eds). Edward Elgar Publishing.

WORKING PAPERS

1. Read All Around It: The Regional Organization of Newspaper Markets.
2. Following the News: Polarization and the Networked Structure of Attention. **Top Paper Prize**, International Communication Association, 2026.
3. When Machines Start Writing: Assessing the Impact of Generative AI on Journalism Labor Markets. With J. Henrichsen & B. Toff.
4. Complements or Competitors? Examining Human-AI Interactions on Sina Weibo. With M. Zhang.

OPEN-SOURCE SOFTWARE

- [breakingnews](#): Parameter-efficient LLM adaptation for segmenting broadcast transcripts. 2026.

AWARDS & FELLOWSHIPS

Top Paper Prize, International Communication Association	2026
Illinois Distinguished Fellowship (\$75,000)	2021–25
Bart A. Cummings Grant (\$1,200)	2025
Political Networks Graduate Student Fellowship	2025
ICA Political Communication Section Travel Grant	2025
Methodology Center Summer Institute Scholarship (Full support), Purdue University / National Institute on Drug Addiction	2025
SPARK Award for Promising Graduate Students, American Political Science Association (Political Communication Section)	2024
Local Journalism Researchers Workshop Travel Grant, Duke University	2024
National Center for Supercomputing Applications (750,000 × 2 core hours)	2023
Institute of Communications Research Graduate Travel Grant	2022–2025

SELECTED CONFERENCE TALKS

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- Read All Around It: The Regional Organization of Newspaper Markets. *Political Communication Section: Midwest Political Science Association*, 2026. [Full paper]
 - Following the News: Polarization and the Networked Structure of Attention. *Information Systems Division: International Communication Association*, 2026. [Full paper]
– **Top Paper Prize**
 - When Machines Start Writing: Assessing the Impact of Generative AI on Journalism Labor Markets. *Computational Methods Division: International Communication Association*, 2026. [Full paper] With J. Henrichsen & B. Toff.
 - Paper Trails: Place, proximity and spillovers in local news ecosystems. *Political Communication Section: American Political Science Association*, 2025. [Full paper; not presented given travel restrictions]
 - Competitors or Complements? Examining the Effect of Human-AI Interaction on Human-Human Interaction. *Human-Machine Communication Division: International Communication Association*, 2025. [Full paper] With M. Zhang.
 - Dissecting Selectivity in a fragmented media environment: A novel approach. *APSA Political Communication Preconference*, 2024. With H. Taneja.
 - Entwined Realms: Media Contexts and Information Choice. *American Political Science Association*, 2024. [iPoster] With H. Taneja.
 - When News is Entertainment. *International Communication Division: AEJMC*, Philadelphia, PA, 2024. [Poster] With R. Ray & H. Taneja.
 - Beyond Preferences: Contextual Influences on News Diets in High-Choice Environments. *Political Communication Division: AEJMC*, Philadelphia, PA, 2024. [Poster] With H. Taneja.
 - Entwined Realms: Examining Media Contexts and News Choice. *A Computational Turn in Journalism: ICA 2024 Preconference*, Singapore/Virtual, 2024. With H. Taneja.
 - Context Matters: Teachers Talk Media Literacy in the Classroom. *Mass Communication Division: International Communication Association*, Toronto, Canada, 2023. [Full paper] With M. Nelson & M. Spikes.
 - Foregrounding contexts in disinformation studies: A study on the failure of fact-checking in India. *What Comes After Disinformation Studies? ICA Preconference*, Paris, France, 2022. With R. Ray & H. Taneja.
 - Fact checkers fail to overcome partisan divides in two of the world's largest democracies. *Political Communication Division: International Communication Association*, Paris, France, 2022. [Full

paper] With R. Ray & H. Taneja.

- Foregrounding Space and context: A discursive study of fact-checking in India. *South Asia Communication Association: AEJMC*, Virtual, 2021.
- Do fact-checkers overcome partisan divides: An investigation of Indian Twitter users. *International Communication Association*, Virtual, 2021. [Full paper] With R. Ray & H. Taneja.
- The Global in the Local: Inter-cultural Translation in the Backdrop of Global Advertising. *International Symposium on Linguistics Across Disciplines*, Aligarh Muslim University, India, 2018. [Full paper]

WORKSHOPS

- Following the News: Polarization and the Networked Structure of Attention. *PolNet & PaCSS*, Cambridge, MA, 2025.
- Diffused News Cultures: Explaining news cultures through spatial relationships. *Local Journalism Researchers Workshop*, Chapel Hill, NC, 2024.

PRESENTATIONS

- Navigating Narratives: Selective Exposure to Indian Journalists. *Social Media and Society in India*, Ann Arbor, MI/Virtual, 2024.
- How politics and platforms skew media literacy instruction. *Institute of Communications Research*, University of Illinois, Urbana-Champaign, 2022.
- Ahirani: A Sociolinguistic Profile. *Centre for South Asian and Middle Eastern Studies*, University of Illinois, Urbana-Champaign, 2021.
- Foregrounding Space and context: A discursive study of fact-checking in India. *The Great Mediation*, University of Chicago, 2021.
- The Technological Mediation of Political Rhetoric on Twitter. *Mediated Campaigns and Unmediated Politics in Millennial India*, Centre de Sciences Humaines, New Delhi, 2019.

INVITED TALKS

- Classroom contexts: Teachers talk teaching media literacy. [Media Education Lab](#), 2025.
- News and Information Consumption in the Contemporary Media Environment: Are Fact-Checkers Enough? [Jio Institute Masterclass](#), 2024.

TEACHING

Pre-doctoral Fellow

2021–present

University of Illinois, Urbana-Champaign

- **Instructor of Record:** Audience Analysis (ADV 483)
- **Lead Teaching Assistant:** Foundations of Data Curation (CS/IS 598)
- **Teaching Assistant:** Data Management, Curation & Reproducibility (IS 477); Intro to Popular TV and Movies (MACS 100); Intro to Advertising (ADV 150)

Graduate Student Mentor, Undergraduate Research Apprenticeship Program

2022–present

University of Illinois, Urbana-Champaign

- Introduced undergraduates to research on media, information and politics.
- Jury member, Social Issues & Policy and Social Science & Human Behavior panels, Undergraduate Research Symposium 2025 & 2026.

OTHER RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Research Assistant, IMEDIA Group

2021–2022

University of Illinois, Urbana-Champaign

Examined media literacy approaches used by high-school teachers in Illinois through semi-structured interviews.

Student Researcher, Open Markets Institute

Jun–Aug 2021

Center for Liberty and Journalism, Washington, DC

Assisted the Illinois Project team; collected data for multiple research projects.

Research Analyst, Indian Council of Social Science Research

Jan–Apr 2021

New Delhi, India

Developed surveys and interview protocols, oversaw participant recruitment, and coordinated the project team. Findings published in *Communication, Culture & Critique*.

Research Assistant, Indraprastha Institute of Information & Technology

2019–2020

New Delhi, India

Studied media parallelism and framing of policy discourse across news publications during the General Election of 2019 in India.

DATA SCIENCE & TECH

Languages & Tools: R (proficient), Python (intermediate), HTML/CSS (intermediate), L^AT_EX, QGIS/ArcGIS

Statistical Modelling: Statistical inference, causal inference, network analysis and spatial econometrics, statistical learning

ADDITIONAL TRAINING

Chicago School of Experimental Economics Summer Workshop	2025
Methodology Center at Purdue Summer Institute	2025
Computational Linguistics Bootcamp, IIT Delhi	2019
Short-term course on Role of Media in Conflict and Peace	2014
Short-term course on Journalism as a Public Good	2014
Short-term course on Film Appreciation	2013

SERVICE

Reviewing for journals: *Humanities and Social Sciences Communications* — *Nature*; *Journalism Studies*; *New Media & Society*

Reviewing for conferences: International Communication Association (Political Communication, Computational Methods, Journalism Studies, and Human-Machine Communication divisions)

Department: ICR Graduate Student Conference, Organizing Team & Reviewer (2023); ICR Graduate Student Representative (2023–24)

PRESS COVERAGE

- [Q&A with media and politics researcher, Sakshi Bhalla](#). *Centre for Innovation & Sustainability in Local Media*. Syndicated by *Editor & Publisher*.
- [Mandatory media literacy education in Illinois schools impaired by digital divides](#). *University of Illinois News Bureau*.

NON-ACADEMIC EXPERIENCE

Campaign Strategy, Thinkstr Consultancy (*Promoted to Senior*)

Mar 2016–Jul 2018

Gurgaon, India

- Spearheaded strategic communication for NITI Aayog (Government of India), including the nationwide launch of digital payments in a [100-day campaign across 100 Indian cities](#).
- Led the campaigns driving the commercial rollout of the UPI (Unified Payments Interface) system and BHIM app, leading to nationwide adoption and digital onboarding.
- The app achieved 10 million downloads within 10 days of launch, and [over 17 million in the first two months](#).

Associate, D. E. Shaw & Co.

Jun 2015–Feb 2016

Hyderabad, India

Evaluated internal program processes and assisted with implementation strategies across multiple teams, supporting high-volume workflows.

Summer Intern, The Coca-Cola Company (India and Southwest Asia HQ)

Summer 2014

Gurgaon, India

Worked with the Public Affairs and Communication Department; supported corporate responsibility initiatives across Marketing and Public Affairs.

PROFESSIONAL AFFILIATIONS

Member, International Communication Association

Member, American Political Science Association

Affiliate, Center for Information, Technology, and Public Life (CITAP)

LANGUAGES

Native/Proficient: English, Hindi, Punjabi · Beginner: Ahirani